be completed within a few weeks. Everything from the apparatus of the State, including the army, to government assets and debts had to be divided fairly between two sovereign countries. Even chairs, tables, petty cash, books and postage stamps had to be divided. There were many arguments, and often over very petty things. Sets of Encyclopaedia Britannica in government libraries were divided up. There is a story of how the instruments of the police band in Lahore were divided up—a drum for India, a trumpet for Pakistan and so on. In the end, the last trombone was left and the two sides almost came to blows over it. As often happens, the madness of the situation is best captured in fiction; Manto's 'Toba Tek Singh' is a short story about how the inmates of Lahore's mental asylum had to be divided up along communal grounds.

The frictions over dividing government property were minor compared to the real business of dividing territory, particularly the two large provinces of Punjab and Bengal. This job fell to a London barrister, Sir Cyril Radcliffe. He was considered one of the most brilliant lawyers of his time but had had nothing to do with India. His unfamiliarity with India was considered a major advantage as it was felt that this was the only way to ensure impartiality. On 27 June he was called to the office of the Lord Chancellor and given the job. Radcliffe must have been stunned when he heard this. He was being asked to decide the fate of millions of people with no previous knowledge of the territories that he was expected to divide. He must have known that, no matter what he did, his decisions would lead to unhappiness and bloodshed. It was the worst job in the world.

Radcliffe set to work in the sweltering July heat from a lonely bungalow in the Viceregal estate in Delhi. Given the paucity of time, he had no opportunity to visit the lands that he had to divide. Instead, he had to trace out a boundary line on a Royal Engineers map with merely population statistics and maps for company. If he had not already known it, he would soon have realized the near-impossibility of what he was expected to do. The Hindu and Muslim enclaves were haphazardly mixed up. The city of Lahore, for example, was split exactly between the Muslim and the Hindu–Sikh populations (600,000 each). Similarly, Amritsar was a holy city for the